preliminary study at the all-India level, the proposal has been circulated among the State units of the party for opinion … A merger proposal was initiated on the eve of the general election, but it could not be pursued.' In fact, the Punjab units of both parties informed their central leaderships of support for the proposal.[148]

These proposals ultimately went nowhere. By then the leadership issue in the Jan Sangh had been settled, first under Deendayal Upadhyaya, then Vajpayee and Advani. The BJP emerged as a new party in 1980 out of the debris of the Janata Party. It had a new name, a new party symbol and a new start, but it retained the Jan Sangh DNA.

The old party's last two presidents had been Vajpayee and Advani. The BJP's first two were also Vajpayee (1980-1986) and Advani (1986-1991). As a rising party, its politics often adjusted to the ebbs and flows of external constraints, but now that the BJP has power by itself, it has inched closer to the ideological identity and the first principles of the Jan Sangh, adopted in the 1950s, than ever before. From Shaheen Bagh to cow slaughter, in virtually every public controversy on its core principles since 2014, the BJP's responses have been a direct extension of the lines that its forebears took in the Jan Sangh.